

SIT STILL

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Sit Still is a phrase that I and many Black girls have heard from our mothers, friends, and hairdressers while we have gotten our hair braided, styled, and pressed. It is a sentiment of generational love and hardship, a reminder that our hair is seen as both beautiful and difficult to maintain.

350 years ago, when roughly 12 million Africans were brought to the Americas during the transatlantic slave trade, traders forced them to shave their hair to erase their cultural legacy. In the United States, slave owners imparted a prejudiced view of natural hair onto enslaved Africans. This bias still exists today.

During slavery, Black Americans were forced to style their hair using found natural oils and homemade combs. Similarly, they used scrap materials and learned skillmanship to craft tools and furniture for their cabins.

My craft, using completely found and raw materials, reflects this sentiment, honoring the legacy of creation born from necessity.

When the Civil War ended in 1865, chattel slavery was abolished. At the time, Black Codes and Jim Crow laws allowed for racial segregation and restricted the advancement of Black Americans. It was not until 1964 that the Civil Rights Act was passed, prohibiting discrimination.

However, today, the 13th Amendment still allows for slavery as punishment for a convicted crime. Black Americans account for 38.4% of inmates, despite only making up 13% of the United States population. Systemic racism and socioeconomic factors contribute to this disparity.

This chair, although throne-like in structure, is intentionally evocative of prison bars and architecture. It is a reminder of how far we as Black Americans have come, and how far we have to go.

Manifesto

To Use Materials that Matter

Hair is something that defines us all. *Sit Still* asks the viewer to question their own relationship with hair, not just as a part of their physical being, but as a tool for self-expression. In letting the form follow the material, I have allowed the natural strength and modality of hair to shape the final structure.

To Understand and Incorporate my Background

The hair salon is a cornerstone of both Latinx and Black American cultures. Being of both Latina and Black descent, hair is a crucial part of our identity, and the salon acts as a place of community for the people who inhabit it. I have always questioned how to appropriately incorporate my heritage into my design practice. Here, I have centered my ethnicity as a crucial aspect of my design process to help me fully accept and connect with my background.

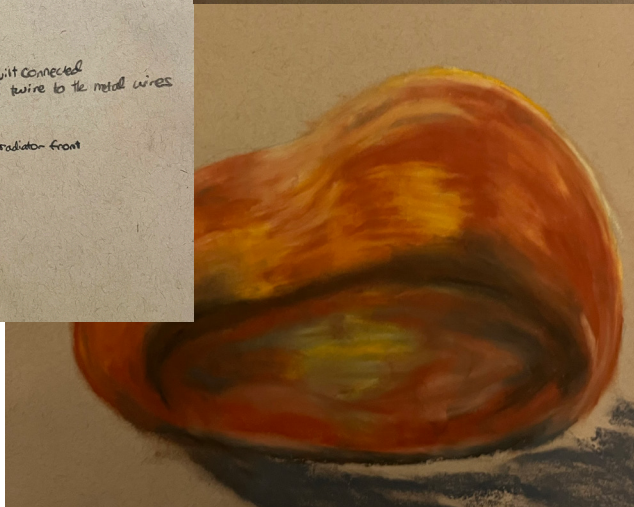
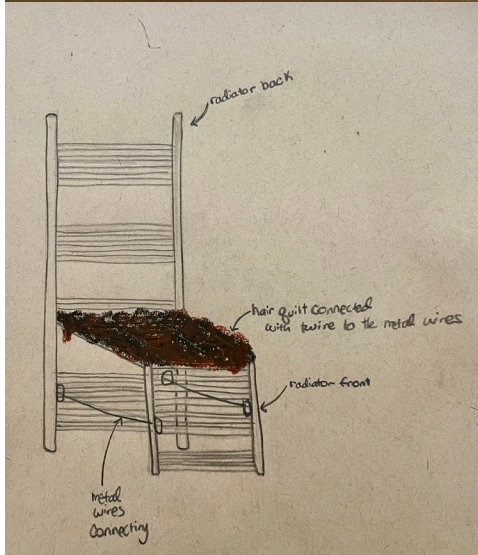
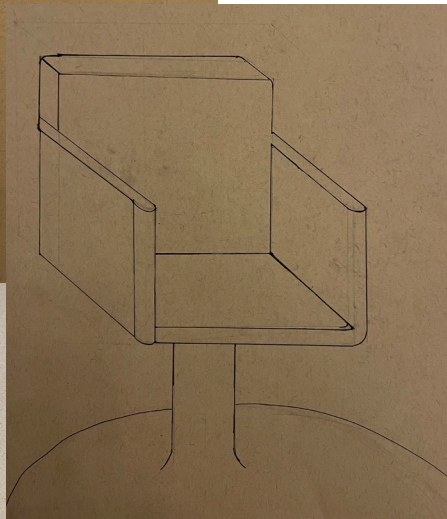
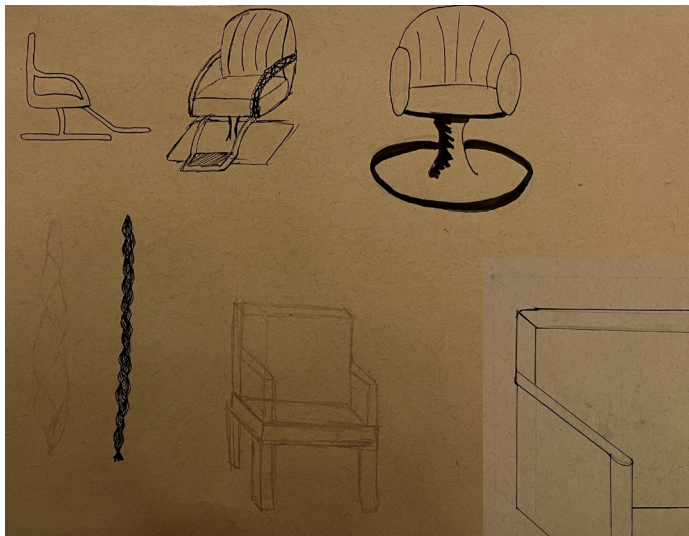
To Reduce Landfill Waste

Approximately 99% of hair waste from salons ends up in landfills. Organizations like Green Salon Collective partner with salons to collect and transform this waste into “hair booms,” which soak up oil spills in oceans. Here, I turn clippings into a textile alternative for upholstery. Similarly, I used scrap metal pieces meant for a landfill as the chair’s frame.

To Center Regenerative Practices

I will always aim to design with a product’s full life cycle, from cradle to grave, in mind. This involves repurposing existing materials, making things that last, and creating with the intention of repurposing the object for future applications.

Sketchbook Drawings



Wire Frame Miniature Prototypes



spot welded
wire frame and
braided nylon hair



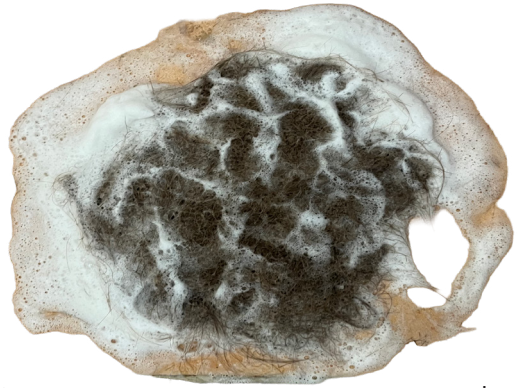
spot welded
wire frame

Material Testing Set Up



separated hair clumps

Felting Process



soapy hair
mat



finished felted
piece

How to Felt Human Hair

1. Separate hair strands with fine-tooth comb
2. Rub palm-sized discs of hair between your hands and on a rough tile floor to make them matted
3. Wet the discs with soapy water and keep matting them by rubbing them between your hands and on the floor
4. Mesh the discs together with soap and water
5. Place the finished piece between paper towels to dry



How to Felt Video

Product Development



needle and
twine

Using twine, I sewed the pieces of felted hair together. Twine's durability reinforces the structure, while its malleability allowed me to weave through the coarse felted hair.

The final form acts as upholstery that covers the seat. While the seat is comfortable and soft to the touch, more layers would have allowed for more longevity.

Due to hair's naturally high tensile strength and its increased stiffness as a result of the felting process, I did not need an additional material layer between the metal frame and the hair.

The quilted pattern is inspired by the African American tradition of quilting. Uniquely made up of raw and vibrant patterns, slaves like Harriet Powers and Dinah Miller shaped the legacy of African American quilting craftsmanship.



hair quilt
sample

Structure Analysis

The frame of the chair was an old radiator I found on the side of the road. I cut the pieces to fit and bolted them together with recovered metal rod, washers, and nuts.

It took multiple tires to wire the chair together to make it ergonomic. At first, there was a slight angle from the back to the front, which created an imbalanced chair. I had to recalibrate the lengths so that the front gaps lined up directly with the back.

After I connected the first version of the frame, I cut down the metal rods to spec and added two rods to a lower row to increase stability.

The final version is upright, like a throne.



first version of the
chair frame



Final Design



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